

SOLVED PRACTICE WORKBOOK

Protecting Honest Officials and Vigilance Administration - Solved Practice Workbook

UPSC complete learning session | Foundation to advanced | Concepts, evidence, practice and answer writing

Protecting Honest Officials and Vigilance Administration

TEN-SESSION CORE PATH • PRACTICE • OPTIONAL ADVANCED • REGISTER NOTES

1 Visual foundation: protection, vigilance and the bona fides test

2 Essential definitions and close legal distinctions

3 Mechanism: screening, verification, evaluation and escalation

4 Indian applications: risk-taking, transfers, dissent and workplace process

5 Must-know facts for Prelims

6 UPSC traps: protection without impunity

7 PYQ application across honest-official and retaliation cases

8 Mains analysis: calibrated safeguards and accountable investigators

9 Probable questions and examiner-ready case routes

10 Study links, current legal uncertainty and final synthesis

Original deterministic study visual; labels are explanatory, not textual quotations.

Source order: repository knowledge -> official current linkage -> clearly marked analysis. No fabricated PYQs or statistics.

CONTENTS / WORKBOOK INDEX

Major learning parts and meaningful subtopics are listed in document order. Page numbers are generated from the final PDF layout; PDF bookmarks mirror the same hierarchy.

Protecting Honest Officials and Vigilance Administration - Solved Practice Workbook	3
BASIC MCQS / REMEDIATION	3
PYQS AND ANSWER PRACTICE	27
ORIGINAL MAINS PRACTICE WITH MODEL SOLUTIONS	32

Protecting Honest Officials and Vigilance Administration - Solved Practice Workbook

Generation: learner-v2:g1 **PYQ ownership:** Questions labelled as official reproduce the locally held UPSC GS-IV papers; routed historical demands are explicitly neutral renderings rather than invented quotations.

BASIC MCQS / REMEDIATION

MCQ 1

A loan approved after documented due diligence later defaults because of an unforeseen market shock. Which test prevents outcome bias from becoming a vigilance charge? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. The bona fides test asks whether a person of common prudence, acting within prescribed rules and for the organisation's genuine interest, could have taken the decision in the circumstances then known.
- B. The Second Administrative Reforms Commission states that vigilance should enhance, not reduce, managerial efficiency; legitimate commercial or administrative risk must remain possible while corrupt motive and reckless rule evasion receive scrutiny.
- C. Contemporaneous reasons, consultation, disclosed conflicts, applicable rules, available information and equal treatment are stronger evidence of good faith than a later assertion that the official merely intended a public benefit.
- D. Honest-official protection is justified by lawful good-faith decision-making rather than seniority, status or institutional prestige; corruption control loses legitimacy when rank alone determines whether credible allegations may be examined.

Answer: A

Explanation: A bad outcome does not by itself prove misconduct is the controlling principle. The bona fides test asks whether a person of common prudence, acting within prescribed rules and for the organisation's genuine interest, could have taken the decision in the circumstances then known. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 2

An officer bypasses mandatory checks to favour a connected borrower and later cites commercial risk. Which feature defeats a claim of bona fides? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Contemporaneous reasons, consultation, disclosed conflicts, applicable rules, available information and equal treatment are stronger evidence of good faith than a later assertion that the official merely intended a public benefit.
- B. The bona fides test asks whether a person of common prudence, acting within prescribed rules and for the organisation's genuine interest, could have taken the decision in the circumstances then known.
- C. Honest-official protection is justified by lawful good-faith decision-making rather than seniority, status or institutional prestige; corruption control loses legitimacy when rank alone determines whether credible allegations may be examined.
- D. The Second Administrative Reforms Commission states that vigilance should enhance, not reduce, managerial efficiency; legitimate commercial or administrative risk must remain possible while corrupt motive and reckless rule evasion receive scrutiny.

Answer: B

Explanation: A bad outcome does not by itself prove misconduct is the controlling principle. The bona fides test asks whether a person of common prudence, acting within prescribed rules and for the organisation's genuine interest, could have taken the decision in the circumstances then known. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 3

A department punishes every innovative decision that produces a loss. Which vigilance purpose identified by the Commission has been reversed? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. The bona fides test asks whether a person of common prudence, acting within prescribed rules and for the organisation's genuine interest, could have taken the decision in the circumstances then known.
- B. Contemporaneous reasons, consultation, disclosed conflicts, applicable rules, available information and equal treatment are stronger evidence of good faith than a later assertion that the official merely intended a public benefit.
- C. The Second Administrative Reforms Commission states that vigilance should enhance, not reduce, managerial efficiency; legitimate commercial or administrative risk must remain possible while corrupt motive and reckless rule evasion receive scrutiny.
- D. Honest-official protection is justified by lawful good-faith decision-making rather than seniority, status or institutional prestige; corruption control loses legitimacy when rank alone determines whether credible allegations may be examined.

Answer: C

Explanation: Risk-taking is compatible with vigilance is the controlling principle. The Second Administrative Reforms Commission states that vigilance should enhance, not reduce, managerial efficiency; legitimate commercial or administrative risk must remain possible while corrupt motive and reckless rule evasion receive scrutiny. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 4

A review distinguishes documented risk from concealed conflict and deliberate deviation. Which calibrated approach is being applied? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Contemporaneous reasons, consultation, disclosed conflicts, applicable rules, available information and equal treatment are stronger evidence of good faith than a later assertion that the official merely intended a public benefit.
- B. Honest-official protection is justified by lawful good-faith decision-making rather than seniority, status or institutional prestige; corruption control loses legitimacy when rank alone determines whether credible allegations may be examined.
- C. The bona fides test asks whether a person of common prudence, acting within prescribed rules and for the organisation's genuine interest, could have taken the decision in the circumstances then known.
- D. The Second Administrative Reforms Commission states that vigilance should enhance, not reduce, managerial efficiency; legitimate commercial or administrative risk must remain possible while corrupt motive and reckless rule evasion receive scrutiny.

Answer: D

Explanation: Risk-taking is compatible with vigilance is the controlling principle. The Second Administrative Reforms Commission states that vigilance should enhance, not reduce, managerial efficiency; legitimate commercial or administrative risk must remain possible while corrupt motive and reckless rule evasion receive scrutiny. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 5

An officer claims good intent but kept no reasons and concealed a relative's interest. Which evidentiary weakness matters most? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Contemporaneous reasons, consultation, disclosed conflicts, applicable rules, available information and equal treatment are stronger evidence of good faith than a later assertion that the official merely intended a public benefit.
- B. The bona fides test asks whether a person of common prudence, acting within prescribed rules and for the organisation's genuine interest, could have taken the decision in the circumstances then known.
- C. The Second Administrative Reforms Commission states that vigilance should enhance, not reduce, managerial efficiency; legitimate commercial or administrative risk must remain possible while corrupt motive and reckless rule evasion receive scrutiny.
- D. Honest-official protection is justified by lawful good-faith decision-making rather than seniority, status or institutional prestige; corruption control loses legitimacy when rank alone determines whether credible allegations may be examined.

Answer: A

Explanation: Process evidence is central to bona fides is the controlling principle. Contemporaneous reasons, consultation, disclosed conflicts, applicable rules, available information and equal treatment are stronger evidence of good faith than a later assertion that the official merely intended a public benefit. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 6

A file records alternatives, expert advice, risk limits and dissent before the decision. How does this support honest decision-making? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. The Second Administrative Reforms Commission states that vigilance should enhance, not reduce, managerial efficiency; legitimate commercial or administrative risk must remain possible while corrupt motive and reckless rule evasion receive scrutiny.
- B. Contemporaneous reasons, consultation, disclosed conflicts, applicable rules, available information and equal treatment are stronger evidence of good faith than a later assertion that the official merely intended a public benefit.
- C. Honest-official protection is justified by lawful good-faith decision-making rather than seniority, status or institutional prestige; corruption control loses legitimacy when rank alone determines whether credible allegations may be examined.
- D. The bona fides test asks whether a person of common prudence, acting within prescribed rules and for the organisation's genuine interest, could have taken the decision in the circumstances then known.

Answer: B

Explanation: Process evidence is central to bona fides is the controlling principle. Contemporaneous reasons, consultation, disclosed conflicts, applicable rules, available information and equal treatment are stronger evidence of good faith than a later assertion that the official merely intended a public benefit. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 7

A rule shields senior officers from scrutiny but exposes junior officers for identical conduct. Which equality defect is present? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. The bona fides test asks whether a person of common prudence, acting within prescribed rules and for the organisation's genuine interest, could have taken the decision in the circumstances then known.
- B. The Second Administrative Reforms Commission states that vigilance should enhance, not reduce, managerial efficiency; legitimate commercial or administrative risk must remain possible while corrupt motive and reckless rule evasion receive scrutiny.
- C. Honest-official protection is justified by lawful good-faith decision-making rather than seniority, status or institutional prestige; corruption control loses legitimacy when rank alone determines whether credible allegations may be examined.
- D. Contemporaneous reasons, consultation, disclosed conflicts, applicable rules, available information and equal treatment are stronger evidence of good faith than a later assertion that the official merely intended a public benefit.

Answer: C

Explanation: Protection follows good faith, not hierarchy is the controlling principle. Honest-official protection is justified by lawful good-faith decision-making rather than seniority, status or institutional prestige; corruption control loses legitimacy when rank alone determines whether credible allegations may be examined. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 8

A rank-neutral process screens allegations by conduct, evidence and official-duty nexus. Which protective principle does it better reflect? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. The Second Administrative Reforms Commission states that vigilance should enhance, not reduce, managerial efficiency; legitimate commercial or administrative risk must remain possible while corrupt motive and reckless rule evasion receive scrutiny.
- B. Contemporaneous reasons, consultation, disclosed conflicts, applicable rules, available information and equal treatment are stronger evidence of good faith than a later assertion that the official merely intended a public benefit.
- C. The bona fides test asks whether a person of common prudence, acting within prescribed rules and for the organisation's genuine interest, could have taken the decision in the circumstances then known.
- D. Honest-official protection is justified by lawful good-faith decision-making rather than seniority, status or institutional prestige; corruption control loses legitimacy when rank alone determines whether credible allegations may be examined.

Answer: D

Explanation: Protection follows good faith, not hierarchy is the controlling principle. Honest-official protection is justified by lawful good-faith decision-making rather than seniority, status or institutional prestige; corruption control loses legitimacy when rank alone determines whether credible allegations may be examined. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 9

An anonymous complaint identifies no act, date, benefit or record, yet immediately triggers public accusation. Which threshold safeguard was omitted? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Before formal inquiry, the Second Administrative Reforms Commission recommends testing each corruption allegation for specificity, credibility and verifiability so that vague hostility does not automatically become coercive process.
- B. Confidential preliminary verification can protect an innocent official's reputation and preserve evidence, but it must not become an indefinite, unreviewed device for burying a specific and credible complaint.
- C. Complex commercial, technical and financial decisions should be evaluated by honest and impartial personnel who understand the domain and consult experts, because ignorance can misclassify ordinary risk as corrupt conduct.
- D. Protecting honest officials does not mean suppressing investigation; it means narrowing coercive action toward persons against whom evidence is strong while separating error, negligence, poor judgment and corrupt intent.

Answer: A

Explanation: Allegations require threshold screening is the controlling principle. Before formal inquiry, the Second Administrative Reforms Commission recommends testing each corruption allegation for specificity, credibility and verifiability so that vague hostility does not automatically become coercive process. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 10

A complaint names the transaction, decision trail, alleged benefit and checkable documents. Why is it suitable for preliminary verification? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Complex commercial, technical and financial decisions should be evaluated by honest and impartial personnel who understand the domain and consult experts, because ignorance can misclassify ordinary risk as corrupt conduct.
- B. Before formal inquiry, the Second Administrative Reforms Commission recommends testing each corruption allegation for specificity, credibility and verifiability so that vague hostility does not automatically become coercive process.
- C. Protecting honest officials does not mean suppressing investigation; it means narrowing coercive action toward persons against whom evidence is strong while separating error, negligence, poor judgment and corrupt intent.
- D. Confidential preliminary verification can protect an innocent official's reputation and preserve evidence, but it must not become an indefinite, unreviewed device for burying a specific and credible complaint.

Answer: B

Explanation: Allegations require threshold screening is the controlling principle. Before formal inquiry, the Second Administrative Reforms Commission recommends testing each corruption allegation for specificity, credibility and verifiability so that vague hostility does not automatically become coercive process. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 11

A false allegation is discreetly checked and closed without publicity. Which legitimate function of secrecy is illustrated? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Before formal inquiry, the Second Administrative Reforms Commission recommends testing each corruption allegation for specificity, credibility and verifiability so that vague hostility does not automatically become coercive process.
- B. Complex commercial, technical and financial decisions should be evaluated by honest and impartial personnel who understand the domain and consult experts, because ignorance can misclassify ordinary risk as corrupt conduct.
- C. Confidential preliminary verification can protect an innocent official's reputation and preserve evidence, but it must not become an indefinite, unreviewed device for burying a specific and credible complaint.
- D. Protecting honest officials does not mean suppressing investigation; it means narrowing coercive action toward persons against whom evidence is strong while separating error, negligence, poor judgment and corrupt intent.

Answer: C

Explanation: Secret verification has a limited protective purpose is the controlling principle. Confidential preliminary verification can protect an innocent official's reputation and preserve evidence, but it must not become an indefinite, unreviewed device for burying a specific and credible complaint. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 12

A credible complaint remains secretly pending for years without reasons or review. Which abuse of the same safeguard appears? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Complex commercial, technical and financial decisions should be evaluated by honest and impartial personnel who understand the domain and consult experts, because ignorance can misclassify ordinary risk as corrupt conduct.
- B. Protecting honest officials does not mean suppressing investigation; it means narrowing coercive action toward persons against whom evidence is strong while separating error, negligence, poor judgment and corrupt intent.
- C. Before formal inquiry, the Second Administrative Reforms Commission recommends testing each corruption allegation for specificity, credibility and verifiability so that vague hostility does not automatically become coercive process.
- D. Confidential preliminary verification can protect an innocent official's reputation and preserve evidence, but it must not become an indefinite, unreviewed device for burying a specific and credible complaint.

Answer: D

Explanation: Secret verification has a limited protective purpose is the controlling principle. Confidential preliminary verification can protect an innocent official's reputation and preserve evidence, but it must not become an indefinite, unreviewed device for burying a specific and credible complaint. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 13

A technically complex procurement decision is judged only by an investigator unfamiliar with the sector. Which Commission safeguard is missing? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Complex commercial, technical and financial decisions should be evaluated by honest and impartial personnel who understand the domain and consult experts, because ignorance can misclassify ordinary risk as corrupt conduct.
- B. Before formal inquiry, the Second Administrative Reforms Commission recommends testing each corruption allegation for specificity, credibility and verifiability so that vague hostility does not automatically become coercive process.
- C. Confidential preliminary verification can protect an innocent official's reputation and preserve evidence, but it must not become an indefinite, unreviewed device for burying a specific and credible complaint.
- D. Protecting honest officials does not mean suppressing investigation; it means narrowing coercive action toward persons against whom evidence is strong while separating error, negligence, poor judgment and corrupt intent.

Answer: A

Explanation: Competence and impartiality determine evaluation quality is the controlling principle. Complex commercial, technical and financial decisions should be evaluated by honest and impartial personnel who understand the domain and consult experts, because ignorance can misclassify ordinary risk as corrupt conduct. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 14

An independent team obtains engineering and financial advice before fixing responsibility. Which evaluation principle is satisfied? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Confidential preliminary verification can protect an innocent official's reputation and preserve evidence, but it must not become an indefinite, unreviewed device for burying a specific and credible complaint.
- B. Complex commercial, technical and financial decisions should be evaluated by honest and impartial personnel who understand the domain and consult experts, because ignorance can misclassify ordinary risk as corrupt conduct.
- C. Protecting honest officials does not mean suppressing investigation; it means narrowing coercive action toward persons against whom evidence is strong while separating error, negligence, poor judgment and corrupt intent.
- D. Before formal inquiry, the Second Administrative Reforms Commission recommends testing each corruption allegation for specificity, credibility and verifiability so that vague hostility does not automatically become coercive process.

Answer: B

Explanation: Competence and impartiality determine evaluation quality is the controlling principle. Complex commercial, technical and financial decisions should be evaluated by honest and impartial personnel who understand the domain and consult experts, because ignorance can misclassify ordinary risk as corrupt conduct. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 15

Investigators implicate everyone who signed a file without identifying knowledge, benefit or agreement. Which overbroad method is being criticised? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Before formal inquiry, the Second Administrative Reforms Commission recommends testing each corruption allegation for specificity, credibility and verifiability so that vague hostility does not automatically become coercive process.
- B. Confidential preliminary verification can protect an innocent official's reputation and preserve evidence, but it must not become an indefinite, unreviewed device for burying a specific and credible complaint.
- C. Protecting honest officials does not mean suppressing investigation; it means narrowing coercive action toward persons against whom evidence is strong while separating error, negligence, poor judgment and corrupt intent.
- D. Complex commercial, technical and financial decisions should be evaluated by honest and impartial personnel who understand the domain and consult experts, because ignorance can misclassify ordinary risk as corrupt conduct.

Answer: C

Explanation: Strong evidence should precede prosecution is the controlling principle. Protecting honest officials does not mean suppressing investigation; it means narrowing coercive action toward persons against whom evidence is strong while separating error, negligence, poor judgment and corrupt intent. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 16

The inquiry identifies the actual beneficiary, concealed communication and deliberate rule evasion before prosecution. Which calibrated standard is shown? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Confidential preliminary verification can protect an innocent official's reputation and preserve evidence, but it must not become an indefinite, unreviewed device for burying a specific and credible complaint.
- B. Complex commercial, technical and financial decisions should be evaluated by honest and impartial personnel who understand the domain and consult experts, because ignorance can misclassify ordinary risk as corrupt conduct.
- C. Before formal inquiry, the Second Administrative Reforms Commission recommends testing each corruption allegation for specificity, credibility and verifiability so that vague hostility does not automatically become coercive process.
- D. Protecting honest officials does not mean suppressing investigation; it means narrowing coercive action toward persons against whom evidence is strong while separating error, negligence, poor judgment and corrupt intent.

Answer: D

Explanation: Strong evidence should precede prosecution is the controlling principle. Protecting honest officials does not mean suppressing investigation; it means narrowing coercive action toward persons against whom evidence is strong while separating error, negligence, poor judgment and corrupt intent. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 17

A candidate describes Section 17A only as permission for a court to begin trial. Which stage has been confused? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. PC Act 17A concerns prior approval before enquiry, inquiry or investigation into an alleged Prevention of Corruption Act offence relating to an official-duty recommendation or decision, subject to its statutory on-the-spot exception.
- B. PC Act 19 requires previous sanction before a court takes cognizance of specified Prevention of Corruption Act offences against a covered public servant; it is distinct from PC Act 17A's earlier investigative-stage approval.
- C. The rank-based Delhi Special Police Establishment Act provision requiring approval to investigate Joint Secretary-level and equivalent officers was struck down in 2014 for violating Article 14; it must not be presented as operative.
- D. On 13 January 2026, two Supreme Court judges expressed divergent opinions on PC Act 17A and directed that the matter be placed before the Chief Justice for an appropriate Bench, leaving the constitutional issue unresolved by that order.

Answer: A

Explanation: Section 17A operates before specified investigative steps is the controlling principle. PC Act 17A concerns prior approval before enquiry, inquiry or investigation into an alleged Prevention of Corruption Act offence relating to an official-duty recommendation or decision, subject to its statutory on-the-spot exception. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 18

An allegation concerns a recorded policy recommendation rather than an on-the-spot bribe. Which approval question ordinarily arises first? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. The rank-based Delhi Special Police Establishment Act provision requiring approval to investigate Joint Secretary-level and equivalent officers was struck down in 2014 for violating Article 14; it must not be presented as operative.
- B. PC Act 17A concerns prior approval before enquiry, inquiry or investigation into an alleged Prevention of Corruption Act offence relating to an official-duty recommendation or decision, subject to its statutory on-the-spot exception.
- C. On 13 January 2026, two Supreme Court judges expressed divergent opinions on PC Act 17A and directed that the matter be placed before the Chief Justice for an appropriate Bench, leaving the constitutional issue unresolved by that order.
- D. PC Act 19 requires previous sanction before a court takes cognizance of specified Prevention of Corruption Act offences against a covered public servant; it is distinct from PC Act 17A's earlier investigative-stage approval.

Answer: B

Explanation: Section 17A operates before specified investigative steps is the controlling principle. PC Act 17A concerns prior approval before enquiry, inquiry or investigation into an alleged Prevention of Corruption Act offence relating to an official-duty recommendation or decision, subject to its statutory on-the-spot exception. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 19

An answer treats sanction for cognizance as identical to approval before inquiry. Which two statutory stages must be separated? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. PC Act 17A concerns prior approval before enquiry, inquiry or investigation into an alleged Prevention of Corruption Act offence relating to an official-duty recommendation or decision, subject to its statutory on-the-spot exception.
- B. The rank-based Delhi Special Police Establishment Act provision requiring approval to investigate Joint Secretary-level and equivalent officers was struck down in 2014 for violating Article 14; it must not be presented as operative.
- C. PC Act 19 requires previous sanction before a court takes cognizance of specified Prevention of Corruption Act offences against a covered public servant; it is distinct from PC Act 17A's earlier investigative-stage approval.
- D. On 13 January 2026, two Supreme Court judges expressed divergent opinions on PC Act 17A and directed that the matter be placed before the Chief Justice for an appropriate Bench, leaving the constitutional issue unresolved by that order.

Answer: C

Explanation: Section 19 is a prosecution-cognizance safeguard is the controlling principle. PC Act 19 requires previous sanction before a court takes cognizance of specified Prevention of Corruption Act offences against a covered public servant; it is distinct from PC Act 17A's earlier investigative-stage approval. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 20

Investigation is completed and the court is asked to take cognizance. Which safeguard becomes directly relevant at this point? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. The rank-based Delhi Special Police Establishment Act provision requiring approval to investigate Joint Secretary-level and equivalent officers was struck down in 2014 for violating Article 14; it must not be presented as operative.
- B. On 13 January 2026, two Supreme Court judges expressed divergent opinions on PC Act 17A and directed that the matter be placed before the Chief Justice for an appropriate Bench, leaving the constitutional issue unresolved by that order.
- C. PC Act 17A concerns prior approval before enquiry, inquiry or investigation into an alleged Prevention of Corruption Act offence relating to an official-duty recommendation or decision, subject to its statutory on-the-spot exception.
- D. PC Act 19 requires previous sanction before a court takes cognizance of specified Prevention of Corruption Act offences against a covered public servant; it is distinct from PC Act 17A's earlier investigative-stage approval.

Answer: D

Explanation: Section 19 is a prosecution-cognizance safeguard is the controlling principle. PC Act 19 requires previous sanction before a court takes cognizance of specified Prevention of Corruption Act offences against a covered public servant; it is distinct from PC Act 17A's earlier investigative-stage approval. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 21

A note says senior rank alone still activates the old single directive. Which constitutional development corrects it? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. The rank-based Delhi Special Police Establishment Act provision requiring approval to investigate Joint Secretary-level and equivalent officers was struck down in 2014 for violating Article 14; it must not be presented as operative.
- B. PC Act 17A concerns prior approval before enquiry, inquiry or investigation into an alleged Prevention of Corruption Act offence relatable to an official-duty recommendation or decision, subject to its statutory on-the-spot exception.
- C. PC Act 19 requires previous sanction before a court takes cognizance of specified Prevention of Corruption Act offences against a covered public servant; it is distinct from PC Act 17A's earlier investigative-stage approval.
- D. On 13 January 2026, two Supreme Court judges expressed divergent opinions on PC Act 17A and directed that the matter be placed before the Chief Justice for an appropriate Bench, leaving the constitutional issue unresolved by that order.

Answer: A

Explanation: The former single directive is not current law is the controlling principle. The rank-based Delhi Special Police Establishment Act provision requiring approval to investigate Joint Secretary-level and equivalent officers was struck down in 2014 for violating Article 14; it must not be presented as operative. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 22

A current analysis instead asks whether alleged conduct is linked to an official-duty decision. Which change in legal framing is recognised? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. PC Act 19 requires previous sanction before a court takes cognizance of specified Prevention of Corruption Act offences against a covered public servant; it is distinct from PC Act 17A's earlier investigative-stage approval.
- B. The rank-based Delhi Special Police Establishment Act provision requiring approval to investigate Joint Secretary-level and equivalent officers was struck down in 2014 for violating Article 14; it must not be presented as operative.
- C. On 13 January 2026, two Supreme Court judges expressed divergent opinions on PC Act 17A and directed that the matter be placed before the Chief Justice for an appropriate Bench, leaving the constitutional issue unresolved by that order.
- D. PC Act 17A concerns prior approval before enquiry, inquiry or investigation into an alleged Prevention of Corruption Act offence relatable to an official-duty recommendation or decision, subject to its statutory on-the-spot exception.

Answer: B

Explanation: The former single directive is not current law is the controlling principle. The rank-based Delhi Special Police Establishment Act provision requiring approval to investigate Joint Secretary-level and equivalent officers was struck down in 2014 for violating Article 14; it must not be presented as operative. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 23

A writer claims the January 2026 order unanimously invalidated Section 17A. Which feature of the official order disproves the claim? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. PC Act 17A concerns prior approval before enquiry, inquiry or investigation into an alleged Prevention of Corruption Act offence relatable to an official-duty recommendation or decision, subject to its statutory on-the-spot exception.
- B. PC Act 19 requires previous sanction before a court takes cognizance of specified Prevention of Corruption Act offences against a covered public servant; it is distinct from PC Act 17A's earlier investigative-stage approval.
- C. On 13 January 2026, two Supreme Court judges expressed divergent opinions on PC Act 17A and directed that the matter be placed before the Chief Justice for an appropriate Bench, leaving the constitutional issue unresolved by that order.
- D. The rank-based Delhi Special Police Establishment Act provision requiring approval to investigate Joint Secretary-level and equivalent officers was struck down in 2014 for violating Article 14; it must not be presented as operative.

Answer: C

Explanation: The 2026 Section 17A case produced no common final holding is the controlling principle. On 13 January 2026, two Supreme Court judges expressed divergent opinions on PC Act 17A and directed that the matter be placed before the Chief Justice for an appropriate Bench, leaving the constitutional issue unresolved by that order. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 24

An answer labels the judgment a split decision referred for fresh consideration. Why is that the accurate current anchor? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. PC Act 19 requires previous sanction before a court takes cognizance of specified Prevention of Corruption Act offences against a covered public servant; it is distinct from PC Act 17A's earlier investigative-stage approval.
- B. The rank-based Delhi Special Police Establishment Act provision requiring approval to investigate Joint Secretary-level and equivalent officers was struck down in 2014 for violating Article 14; it must not be presented as operative.
- C. PC Act 17A concerns prior approval before enquiry, inquiry or investigation into an alleged Prevention of Corruption Act offence relatable to an official-duty recommendation or decision, subject to its statutory on-the-spot exception.
- D. On 13 January 2026, two Supreme Court judges expressed divergent opinions on PC Act 17A and directed that the matter be placed before the Chief Justice for an appropriate Bench, leaving the constitutional issue unresolved by that order.

Answer: D

Explanation: The 2026 Section 17A case produced no common final holding is the controlling principle. On 13 January 2026, two Supreme Court judges expressed divergent opinions on PC Act 17A and directed that the matter be placed before the Chief Justice for an appropriate Bench, leaving the constitutional issue unresolved by that order. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 25

An agency insists that scrutiny of investigators always destroys independence. Which Commission recommendation answers that position? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. The Second Administrative Reforms Commission proposed a specialised unit linked to the proposed Lok Pal or State Lokayukta to examine corruption by investigating agencies and allegations that investigators themselves harassed officials.
- B. The Commission warned that assuming every wrong decision implies corruption and implicating the entire decision chain can demoralise honest officials, lower precision, waste capacity and allow actual wrongdoers to escape.
- C. Arbitrary transfer can punish an honest officer without formal disciplinary action, destabilise professional independence and convert postings into transactions; transparent policy and minimum tenure are therefore integrity safeguards.
- D. Minimum tenure should reduce punitive transfers, yet urgent reassignment may remain legitimate where continued posting creates conflict, evidence risk or serious operational harm; any exception should be narrow, recorded and reviewable.

Answer: A

Explanation: **Investigators require accountability too** is the controlling principle. The Second Administrative Reforms Commission proposed a specialised unit linked to the proposed Lok Pal or State Lokayukta to examine corruption by investigating agencies and allegations that investigators themselves harassed officials. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 26

A separate competent body examines fabricated evidence and retaliatory investigation. Which watch-the-watchers principle is applied? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Arbitrary transfer can punish an honest officer without formal disciplinary action, destabilise professional independence and convert postings into transactions; transparent policy and minimum tenure are therefore integrity safeguards.
- B. The Second Administrative Reforms Commission proposed a specialised unit linked to the proposed Lok Pal or State Lokayukta to examine corruption by investigating agencies and allegations that investigators themselves harassed officials.
- C. Minimum tenure should reduce punitive transfers, yet urgent reassignment may remain legitimate where continued posting creates conflict, evidence risk or serious operational harm; any exception should be narrow, recorded and reviewable.
- D. The Commission warned that assuming every wrong decision implies corruption and implicating the entire decision chain can demoralise honest officials, lower precision, waste capacity and allow actual wrongdoers to escape.

Answer: B

Explanation: **Investigators require accountability too** is the controlling principle. The Second Administrative Reforms Commission proposed a specialised unit linked to the proposed Lok Pal or State Lokayukta to examine corruption by investigating agencies and allegations that investigators themselves harassed officials. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 27

Every signatory is accused of conspiracy solely because a project failed. Which two-sided vigilance failure mode appears? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. The Second Administrative Reforms Commission proposed a specialised unit linked to the proposed Lok Pal or State Lokayukta to examine corruption by investigating agencies and allegations that investigators themselves harassed officials.
- B. Arbitrary transfer can punish an honest officer without formal disciplinary action, destabilise professional independence and convert postings into transactions; transparent policy and minimum tenure are therefore integrity safeguards.
- C. The Commission warned that assuming every wrong decision implies corruption and implicating the entire decision chain can demoralise honest officials, lower precision, waste capacity and allow actual wrongdoers to escape.
- D. Minimum tenure should reduce punitive transfers, yet urgent reassignment may remain legitimate where continued posting creates conflict, evidence risk or serious operational harm; any exception should be narrow, recorded and reviewable.

Answer: C

Explanation: **Over-suspicion can weaken anti-corruption outcomes** is the controlling principle. The Commission warned that assuming every wrong decision implies corruption and implicating the entire decision chain can demoralise honest officials, lower precision, waste capacity and allow actual wrongdoers to escape. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 28

Investigators isolate who knew, benefited, concealed and deliberately deviated. How does this improve both fairness and enforcement? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Arbitrary transfer can punish an honest officer without formal disciplinary action, destabilise professional independence and convert postings into transactions; transparent policy and minimum tenure are therefore integrity safeguards.
- B. Minimum tenure should reduce punitive transfers, yet urgent reassignment may remain legitimate where continued posting creates conflict, evidence risk or serious operational harm; any exception should be narrow, recorded and reviewable.
- C. The Second Administrative Reforms Commission proposed a specialised unit linked to the proposed Lok Pal or State Lokayukta to examine corruption by investigating agencies and allegations that investigators themselves harassed officials.
- D. The Commission warned that assuming every wrong decision implies corruption and implicating the entire decision chain can demoralise honest officials, lower precision, waste capacity and allow actual wrongdoers to escape.

Answer: D

Explanation: **Over-suspicion can weaken anti-corruption outcomes** is the controlling principle. The Commission warned that assuming every wrong decision implies corruption and implicating the entire decision chain can demoralise honest officials, lower precision, waste capacity and allow actual wrongdoers to escape. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 29

An officer is moved immediately after refusing political favour, without stated administrative grounds. Which harassment mechanism is illustrated? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Arbitrary transfer can punish an honest officer without formal disciplinary action, destabilise professional independence and convert postings into transactions; transparent policy and minimum tenure are therefore integrity safeguards.
- B. The Second Administrative Reforms Commission proposed a specialised unit linked to the proposed Lok Pal or State Lokayukta to examine corruption by investigating agencies and allegations that investigators themselves harassed officials.
- C. The Commission warned that assuming every wrong decision implies corruption and implicating the entire decision chain can demoralise honest officials, lower precision, waste capacity and allow actual wrongdoers to escape.
- D. Minimum tenure should reduce punitive transfers, yet urgent reassignment may remain legitimate where continued posting creates conflict, evidence risk or serious operational harm; any exception should be narrow, recorded and reviewable.

Answer: A

Explanation: The transfer industry is soft retaliation is the controlling principle. Arbitrary transfer can punish an honest officer without formal disciplinary action, destabilise professional independence and convert postings into transactions; transparent policy and minimum tenure are therefore integrity safeguards. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 30

A published policy requires reasons, tenure norms and review of premature transfer. Which corrective architecture is present? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. The Commission warned that assuming every wrong decision implies corruption and implicating the entire decision chain can demoralise honest officials, lower precision, waste capacity and allow actual wrongdoers to escape.
- B. Arbitrary transfer can punish an honest officer without formal disciplinary action, destabilise professional independence and convert postings into transactions; transparent policy and minimum tenure are therefore integrity safeguards.
- C. Minimum tenure should reduce punitive transfers, yet urgent reassignment may remain legitimate where continued posting creates conflict, evidence risk or serious operational harm; any exception should be narrow, recorded and reviewable.
- D. The Second Administrative Reforms Commission proposed a specialised unit linked to the proposed Lok Pal or State Lokayukta to examine corruption by investigating agencies and allegations that investigators themselves harassed officials.

Answer: B

Explanation: The transfer industry is soft retaliation is the controlling principle. Arbitrary transfer can punish an honest officer without formal disciplinary action, destabilise professional independence and convert postings into transactions; transparent policy and minimum tenure are therefore integrity safeguards. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 31

A tenure rule prevents moving an officer who is tampering with a live inquiry. Which qualification has been ignored? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. The Second Administrative Reforms Commission proposed a specialised unit linked to the proposed Lok Pal or State Lokayukta to examine corruption by investigating agencies and allegations that investigators themselves harassed officials.
- B. The Commission warned that assuming every wrong decision implies corruption and implicating the entire decision chain can demoralise honest officials, lower precision, waste capacity and allow actual wrongdoers to escape.
- C. Minimum tenure should reduce punitive transfers, yet urgent reassignment may remain legitimate where continued posting creates conflict, evidence risk or serious operational harm; any exception should be narrow, recorded and reviewable.
- D. Arbitrary transfer can punish an honest officer without formal disciplinary action, destabilise professional independence and convert postings into transactions; transparent policy and minimum tenure are therefore integrity safeguards.

Answer: C

Explanation: Tenure protection needs justified exceptions is the controlling principle. Minimum tenure should reduce punitive transfers, yet urgent reassignment may remain legitimate where continued posting creates conflict, evidence risk or serious operational harm; any exception should be narrow, recorded and reviewable. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 32

A premature transfer order records evidence risk and receives independent review. Which balance is being maintained? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. The Commission warned that assuming every wrong decision implies corruption and implicating the entire decision chain can demoralise honest officials, lower precision, waste capacity and allow actual wrongdoers to escape.
- B. Arbitrary transfer can punish an honest officer without formal disciplinary action, destabilise professional independence and convert postings into transactions; transparent policy and minimum tenure are therefore integrity safeguards.
- C. The Second Administrative Reforms Commission proposed a specialised unit linked to the proposed Lok Pal or State Lokayukta to examine corruption by investigating agencies and allegations that investigators themselves harassed officials.
- D. Minimum tenure should reduce punitive transfers, yet urgent reassignment may remain legitimate where continued posting creates conflict, evidence risk or serious operational harm; any exception should be narrow, recorded and reviewable.

Answer: D

Explanation: Tenure protection needs justified exceptions is the controlling principle. Minimum tenure should reduce punitive transfers, yet urgent reassignment may remain legitimate where continued posting creates conflict, evidence risk or serious operational harm; any exception should be narrow, recorded and reviewable. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 33

A superior orally orders favour to a bidder and the officer obeys without noting objection. Which protective step was missed? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. When pressured to act improperly, an official should seek written instructions, record facts and reasons, state a reasoned dissent and preserve the decision trail rather than rely on oral refusal or silent compliance.
- B. The whistleblowing ladder begins with evidence preservation and internal or authorised vigilance reporting, then uses higher independent channels if capture persists; public disclosure is reserved for grave residual harm and lawful necessity.
- C. Immediate resignation may abandon records, institutional duty and affected citizens; the official should first document, dissent, escalate, seek protection and reduce harm unless continued service itself requires direct illegality.
- D. A protected reporting system needs restricted identity access, secure records, retaliation monitoring, interim safety measures and review of adverse postings; secrecy alone is inadequate if reprisals remain easy and invisible.

Answer: A

Explanation: Written dissent converts conscience into an administrative record is the controlling principle.

When pressured to act improperly, an official should seek written instructions, record facts and reasons, state a reasoned dissent and preserve the decision trail rather than rely on oral refusal or silent compliance. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 34

The officer records the direction, relevant rule, public risk and lawful alternative. What ethical function does this dissent serve? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Immediate resignation may abandon records, institutional duty and affected citizens; the official should first document, dissent, escalate, seek protection and reduce harm unless continued service itself requires direct illegality.
- B. When pressured to act improperly, an official should seek written instructions, record facts and reasons, state a reasoned dissent and preserve the decision trail rather than rely on oral refusal or silent compliance.
- C. A protected reporting system needs restricted identity access, secure records, retaliation monitoring, interim safety measures and review of adverse postings; secrecy alone is inadequate if reprisals remain easy and invisible.
- D. The whistleblowing ladder begins with evidence preservation and internal or authorised vigilance reporting, then uses higher independent channels if capture persists; public disclosure is reserved for grave residual harm and lawful necessity.

Answer: B

Explanation: Written dissent converts conscience into an administrative record is the controlling principle.

When pressured to act improperly, an official should seek written instructions, record facts and reasons, state a reasoned dissent and preserve the decision trail rather than rely on oral refusal or silent compliance. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 35

An officer uploads unverified allegations before using any protected channel. Which sequencing problem does this create? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. When pressured to act improperly, an official should seek written instructions, record facts and reasons, state a reasoned dissent and preserve the decision trail rather than rely on oral refusal or silent compliance.
- B. Immediate resignation may abandon records, institutional duty and affected citizens; the official should first document, dissent, escalate, seek protection and reduce harm unless continued service itself requires direct illegality.
- C. The whistleblowing ladder begins with evidence preservation and internal or authorised vigilance reporting, then uses higher independent channels if capture persists; public disclosure is reserved for grave residual harm and lawful necessity.
- D. A protected reporting system needs restricted identity access, secure records, retaliation monitoring, interim safety measures and review of adverse postings; secrecy alone is inadequate if reprisals remain easy and invisible.

Answer: C

Explanation: **Escalation should ordinarily begin through authorised channels** is the controlling principle. The whistleblowing ladder begins with evidence preservation and internal or authorised vigilance reporting, then uses higher independent channels if capture persists; public disclosure is reserved for grave residual harm and lawful necessity. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 36

Records are secured, the CVO is approached and an independent authority is used after internal capture. Which ladder is followed? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Immediate resignation may abandon records, institutional duty and affected citizens; the official should first document, dissent, escalate, seek protection and reduce harm unless continued service itself requires direct illegality.
- B. A protected reporting system needs restricted identity access, secure records, retaliation monitoring, interim safety measures and review of adverse postings; secrecy alone is inadequate if reprisals remain easy and invisible.
- C. When pressured to act improperly, an official should seek written instructions, record facts and reasons, state a reasoned dissent and preserve the decision trail rather than rely on oral refusal or silent compliance.
- D. The whistleblowing ladder begins with evidence preservation and internal or authorised vigilance reporting, then uses higher independent channels if capture persists; public disclosure is reserved for grave residual harm and lawful necessity.

Answer: D

Explanation: **Escalation should ordinarily begin through authorised channels** is the controlling principle. The whistleblowing ladder begins with evidence preservation and internal or authorised vigilance reporting, then uses higher independent channels if capture persists; public disclosure is reserved for grave residual harm and lawful necessity. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 37

An officer resigns before preserving evidence of procurement manipulation. Which public-duty concern arises? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Immediate resignation may abandon records, institutional duty and affected citizens; the official should first document, dissent, escalate, seek protection and reduce harm unless continued service itself requires direct illegality.
- B. When pressured to act improperly, an official should seek written instructions, record facts and reasons, state a reasoned dissent and preserve the decision trail rather than rely on oral refusal or silent compliance.
- C. The whistleblowing ladder begins with evidence preservation and internal or authorised vigilance reporting, then uses higher independent channels if capture persists; public disclosure is reserved for grave residual harm and lawful necessity.
- D. A protected reporting system needs restricted identity access, secure records, retaliation monitoring, interim safety measures and review of adverse postings; secrecy alone is inadequate if reprisals remain easy and invisible.

Answer: A

Explanation: Resignation is usually not the first ethical response is the controlling principle. Immediate resignation may abandon records, institutional duty and affected citizens; the official should first document, dissent, escalate, seek protection and reduce harm unless continued service itself requires direct illegality. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 38

The officer refuses illegality, records reasons and activates oversight while remaining available for lawful implementation. Which approach is stronger? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. The whistleblowing ladder begins with evidence preservation and internal or authorised vigilance reporting, then uses higher independent channels if capture persists; public disclosure is reserved for grave residual harm and lawful necessity.
- B. Immediate resignation may abandon records, institutional duty and affected citizens; the official should first document, dissent, escalate, seek protection and reduce harm unless continued service itself requires direct illegality.
- C. A protected reporting system needs restricted identity access, secure records, retaliation monitoring, interim safety measures and review of adverse postings; secrecy alone is inadequate if reprisals remain easy and invisible.
- D. When pressured to act improperly, an official should seek written instructions, record facts and reasons, state a reasoned dissent and preserve the decision trail rather than rely on oral refusal or silent compliance.

Answer: B

Explanation: Resignation is usually not the first ethical response is the controlling principle. Immediate resignation may abandon records, institutional duty and affected citizens; the official should first document, dissent, escalate, seek protection and reduce harm unless continued service itself requires direct illegality. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 39

A complainant's name is hidden, but a punitive transfer follows without review. Which safeguard remains incomplete? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. When pressured to act improperly, an official should seek written instructions, record facts and reasons, state a reasoned dissent and preserve the decision trail rather than rely on oral refusal or silent compliance.
- B. The whistleblowing ladder begins with evidence preservation and internal or authorised vigilance reporting, then uses higher independent channels if capture persists; public disclosure is reserved for grave residual harm and lawful necessity.
- C. A protected reporting system needs restricted identity access, secure records, retaliation monitoring, interim safety measures and review of adverse postings; secrecy alone is inadequate if reprisals remain easy and invisible.
- D. Immediate resignation may abandon records, institutional duty and affected citizens; the official should first document, dissent, escalate, seek protection and reduce harm unless continued service itself requires direct illegality.

Answer: C

Explanation: Confidentiality must accompany anti-retaliation is the controlling principle. A protected reporting system needs restricted identity access, secure records, retaliation monitoring, interim safety measures and review of adverse postings; secrecy alone is inadequate if reprisals remain easy and invisible. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 40

Access logs, safety assessment and independent review of adverse action accompany confidential reporting. Which design is illustrated? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. The whistleblowing ladder begins with evidence preservation and internal or authorised vigilance reporting, then uses higher independent channels if capture persists; public disclosure is reserved for grave residual harm and lawful necessity.
- B. Immediate resignation may abandon records, institutional duty and affected citizens; the official should first document, dissent, escalate, seek protection and reduce harm unless continued service itself requires direct illegality.
- C. When pressured to act improperly, an official should seek written instructions, record facts and reasons, state a reasoned dissent and preserve the decision trail rather than rely on oral refusal or silent compliance.
- D. A protected reporting system needs restricted identity access, secure records, retaliation monitoring, interim safety measures and review of adverse postings; secrecy alone is inadequate if reprisals remain easy and invisible.

Answer: D

Explanation: Confidentiality must accompany anti-retaliation is the controlling principle. A protected reporting system needs restricted identity access, secure records, retaliation monitoring, interim safety measures and review of adverse postings; secrecy alone is inadequate if reprisals remain easy and invisible. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 41

A builder threatens a fabricated workplace complaint to stop a corruption inquiry. Which dual-process response is required? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. The Internal Committee conducts workplace due process for sexual-harassment complaints, while vigilance machinery examines corruption-related misconduct; neither route should be manipulated to suppress the other or prejudge criminal responsibility.
- B. A credible sexual-harassment system must enable complaint, confidentiality, assistance and protection from victimisation while also providing an impartial inquiry, defined allegations, opportunity to respond and reasoned recommendations.
- C. Approval, sanction, confidentiality and tenure rules are legitimate only when applied promptly, independently and with recorded reasons; indefinite delay or partisan control converts protection of honest action into impunity for misconduct.
- D. A credible vigilance system filters malice, protects lawful risk-taking and checks investigator abuse, yet also preserves evidence, reviews refusals, prosecutes strong cases and prevents hierarchy or procedure from blocking accountability.

Answer: A

Explanation: POSH inquiry is distinct from corruption vigilance is the controlling principle. The Internal Committee conducts workplace due process for sexual-harassment complaints, while vigilance machinery examines corruption-related misconduct; neither route should be manipulated to suppress the other or prejudge criminal responsibility. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 42

The corruption evidence is preserved while an independent Internal Committee fairly examines the separate complaint. Which boundary is respected? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Approval, sanction, confidentiality and tenure rules are legitimate only when applied promptly, independently and with recorded reasons; indefinite delay or partisan control converts protection of honest action into impunity for misconduct.
- B. The Internal Committee conducts workplace due process for sexual-harassment complaints, while vigilance machinery examines corruption-related misconduct; neither route should be manipulated to suppress the other or prejudge criminal responsibility.
- C. A credible vigilance system filters malice, protects lawful risk-taking and checks investigator abuse, yet also preserves evidence, reviews refusals, prosecutes strong cases and prevents hierarchy or procedure from blocking accountability.
- D. A credible sexual-harassment system must enable complaint, confidentiality, assistance and protection from victimisation while also providing an impartial inquiry, defined allegations, opportunity to respond and reasoned recommendations.

Answer: B

Explanation: POSH inquiry is distinct from corruption vigilance is the controlling principle. The Internal Committee conducts workplace due process for sexual-harassment complaints, while vigilance machinery examines corruption-related misconduct; neither route should be manipulated to suppress the other or prejudge criminal responsibility. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 43

Management pays a complainant to withdraw and declare the respondent innocent. Which institutional duties are defeated? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. The Internal Committee conducts workplace due process for sexual-harassment complaints, while vigilance machinery examines corruption-related misconduct; neither route should be manipulated to suppress the other or prejudge criminal responsibility.
- B. Approval, sanction, confidentiality and tenure rules are legitimate only when applied promptly, independently and with recorded reasons; indefinite delay or partisan control converts protection of honest action into impunity for misconduct.
- C. A credible sexual-harassment system must enable complaint, confidentiality, assistance and protection from victimisation while also providing an impartial inquiry, defined allegations, opportunity to respond and reasoned recommendations.
- D. A credible vigilance system filters malice, protects lawful risk-taking and checks investigator abuse, yet also preserves evidence, reviews refusals, prosecutes strong cases and prevents hierarchy or procedure from blocking accountability.

Answer: C

Explanation: POSH protection does not erase respondent due process is the controlling principle. A credible sexual-harassment system must enable complaint, confidentiality, assistance and protection from victimisation while also providing an impartial inquiry, defined allegations, opportunity to respond and reasoned recommendations. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 44

The committee protects participants, tests evidence and gives both sides procedural fairness. Which balanced standard is applied? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Approval, sanction, confidentiality and tenure rules are legitimate only when applied promptly, independently and with recorded reasons; indefinite delay or partisan control converts protection of honest action into impunity for misconduct.
- B. A credible vigilance system filters malice, protects lawful risk-taking and checks investigator abuse, yet also preserves evidence, reviews refusals, prosecutes strong cases and prevents hierarchy or procedure from blocking accountability.
- C. The Internal Committee conducts workplace due process for sexual-harassment complaints, while vigilance machinery examines corruption-related misconduct; neither route should be manipulated to suppress the other or prejudge criminal responsibility.
- D. A credible sexual-harassment system must enable complaint, confidentiality, assistance and protection from victimisation while also providing an impartial inquiry, defined allegations, opportunity to respond and reasoned recommendations.

Answer: D

Explanation: POSH protection does not erase respondent due process is the controlling principle. A credible sexual-harassment system must enable complaint, confidentiality, assistance and protection from victimisation while also providing an impartial inquiry, defined allegations, opportunity to respond and reasoned recommendations. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 45

A competent authority ignores a complete evidence file until limitation risks arise. Which safeguard misuse is present? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Approval, sanction, confidentiality and tenure rules are legitimate only when applied promptly, independently and with recorded reasons; indefinite delay or partisan control converts protection of honest action into impunity for misconduct.
- B. The Internal Committee conducts workplace due process for sexual-harassment complaints, while vigilance machinery examines corruption-related misconduct; neither route should be manipulated to suppress the other or prejudge criminal responsibility.
- C. A credible sexual-harassment system must enable complaint, confidentiality, assistance and protection from victimisation while also providing an impartial inquiry, defined allegations, opportunity to respond and reasoned recommendations.
- D. A credible vigilance system filters malice, protects lawful risk-taking and checks investigator abuse, yet also preserves evidence, reviews refusals, prosecutes strong cases and prevents hierarchy or procedure from blocking accountability.

Answer: A

Explanation: Safeguards cannot become shields for corruption is the controlling principle. Approval, sanction, confidentiality and tenure rules are legitimate only when applied promptly, independently and with recorded reasons; indefinite delay or partisan control converts protection of honest action into impunity for misconduct. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 46

A time-bound reasoned decision distinguishes bona fide judgment from concealed benefit. Which protective balance is achieved? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. A credible sexual-harassment system must enable complaint, confidentiality, assistance and protection from victimisation while also providing an impartial inquiry, defined allegations, opportunity to respond and reasoned recommendations.
- B. Approval, sanction, confidentiality and tenure rules are legitimate only when applied promptly, independently and with recorded reasons; indefinite delay or partisan control converts protection of honest action into impunity for misconduct.
- C. A credible vigilance system filters malice, protects lawful risk-taking and checks investigator abuse, yet also preserves evidence, reviews refusals, prosecutes strong cases and prevents hierarchy or procedure from blocking accountability.
- D. The Internal Committee conducts workplace due process for sexual-harassment complaints, while vigilance machinery examines corruption-related misconduct; neither route should be manipulated to suppress the other or prejudge criminal responsibility.

Answer: B

Explanation: Safeguards cannot become shields for corruption is the controlling principle. Approval, sanction, confidentiality and tenure rules are legitimate only when applied promptly, independently and with recorded reasons; indefinite delay or partisan control converts protection of honest action into impunity for misconduct. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 47

A reform proposal only increases immunity for officials. Which half of the symmetric design is missing? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. The Internal Committee conducts workplace due process for sexual-harassment complaints, while vigilance machinery examines corruption-related misconduct; neither route should be manipulated to suppress the other or prejudge criminal responsibility.
- B. A credible sexual-harassment system must enable complaint, confidentiality, assistance and protection from victimisation while also providing an impartial inquiry, defined allegations, opportunity to respond and reasoned recommendations.
- C. A credible vigilance system filters malice, protects lawful risk-taking and checks investigator abuse, yet also preserves evidence, reviews refusals, prosecutes strong cases and prevents hierarchy or procedure from blocking accountability.
- D. Approval, sanction, confidentiality and tenure rules are legitimate only when applied promptly, independently and with recorded reasons; indefinite delay or partisan control converts protection of honest action into impunity for misconduct.

Answer: C

Explanation: Protection without impunity needs symmetric design is the controlling principle. A credible vigilance system filters malice, protects lawful risk-taking and checks investigator abuse, yet also preserves evidence, reviews refusals, prosecutes strong cases and prevents hierarchy or procedure from blocking accountability. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 48

Another proposal abolishes every safeguard and equates accusation with guilt. Which opposite failure does it create? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. A credible sexual-harassment system must enable complaint, confidentiality, assistance and protection from victimisation while also providing an impartial inquiry, defined allegations, opportunity to respond and reasoned recommendations.
- B. Approval, sanction, confidentiality and tenure rules are legitimate only when applied promptly, independently and with recorded reasons; indefinite delay or partisan control converts protection of honest action into impunity for misconduct.
- C. The Internal Committee conducts workplace due process for sexual-harassment complaints, while vigilance machinery examines corruption-related misconduct; neither route should be manipulated to suppress the other or prejudge criminal responsibility.
- D. A credible vigilance system filters malice, protects lawful risk-taking and checks investigator abuse, yet also preserves evidence, reviews refusals, prosecutes strong cases and prevents hierarchy or procedure from blocking accountability.

Answer: D

Explanation: Protection without impunity needs symmetric design is the controlling principle. A credible vigilance system filters malice, protects lawful risk-taking and checks investigator abuse, yet also preserves evidence, reviews refusals, prosecutes strong cases and prevents hierarchy or procedure from blocking accountability. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

PYQS AND ANSWER PRACTICE

Solved PYQ 1 - 2019 - 20 marks

Question: GS-IV Q8: Honesty and uprightness are the hallmarks of a civil servant. Civil servants possessing these qualities are considered as the backbone of any strong organization. In line of duty, they take various decisions, at times some become bonafide mistakes. As long as such decisions are not taken intentionally and do not benefit personally, the officer cannot be said to be guilty. Though such decisions may, at times, lead to unforeseen adverse consequences in the long-term. In the recent past, a few instances have surfaced wherein civil servants have been implicated for bonafide mistakes. They have often been prosecuted and even imprisoned. These instances have greatly rattled the moral fibre of the civil servants. How does this trend affect the functioning of the civil services? What measures can be taken to ensure that honest civil servants are not implicated for bonafide mistakes on their part? Justify your answer. (250 words)

Source / ownership: Exact English wording verified against books\more_previous_papers\QP-CSM19-GeneralStudies-IV.pdf, page 5. The official paper uses the spelling 'bonafide'; the model answer retains the question while applying ARC's bona fides test.

Model solution

Fear of implication changes administrative behaviour before any case is filed. Officers avoid innovation, defer decisions through unnecessary committees, refuse difficult postings and privilege personal safety over public value. Honest and dishonest officials then become indistinguishable in a culture of defensive delay. Institutional morale falls, talented officers exit sensitive assignments and citizens bear slower delivery.

Protection should begin with ARC's bona fides test: would a prudent person, working within rules and using the information then available, have taken the decision in the organisation's genuine interest? Review must examine contemporaneous reasons, due diligence, disclosed interests, expert advice and personal benefit, not merely the later outcome. Specificity, credibility and verifiability screening should precede discreet preliminary checking. Technically competent and impartial investigators should identify actual knowledge, benefit and deliberate rule evasion rather than implicating every signatory.

Section 17A and Section 19 represent different statutory safeguards, but approvals and sanctions must be timely, reasoned and reviewable so they do not shelter corruption. Investigators should themselves face independent accountability for fabricated or retaliatory cases. Transparent transfer policies, minimum tenure, written instructions and protected reporting channels address softer forms of harassment.

The aim is neither official immunity nor accusation-based punishment. A calibrated system protects good-faith risk-taking while pursuing strong evidence against actual misconduct.

Why this earns marks: It states the governing ethical idea, translates it into public administration, uses a concrete Indian illustration, acknowledges a limit, and ends with a reasoned verdict.

Solved PYQ 2 - 2019 - 20 marks

Question: GS-IV Q9 case study: A successful marketing executive in an apparel company is accused by a woman employee of workplace sexual harassment. Management initially ignores her grievance and later offers money for withdrawal of both the complaint and FIR, along with a written declaration exonerating the executive. Identify the ethical issues and the options available to the woman employee. (250 words)

Source / ownership: Neutral routing verified against

books\more_previous_papers\QP-CSM19-GeneralStudies-IV.pdf, page 5. The official stem is longer; this entry preserves its parties, pressure, complaint, FIR and demands without claiming verbatim reproduction.

Model solution

The issues are sexual harassment, managerial indifference, abuse of economic power, attempted suppression of evidence, retaliation risk, conflict between sales performance and dignity, and denial of institutional due process. The payment offer also seeks a false declaration, converting settlement pressure into an integrity problem.

The employee may insist that the employer activate the Internal Committee, preserve messages and witness accounts, seek confidentiality and interim protection, continue the police process where she chooses, approach the Local Committee or competent authority if the workplace mechanism is absent or compromised, and obtain legal or counselling support. She should not be compelled to choose between workplace inquiry and criminal process because they are distinct routes.

The employer must constitute and assist the committee, prevent victimisation, avoid predetermining guilt, and act on reasoned recommendations. The respondent must receive defined allegations and a fair opportunity to answer; protecting the complainant does not authorise a sham inquiry. Equally, commercial value cannot excuse harassment or institutional capture.

Her strongest course is to reject coercive withdrawal, document the offer, use the Internal Committee with safeguards, and continue lawful external remedies as advised. Dignity, truth and fair procedure must prevail over both corporate reputation management and allegation-based condemnation.

Why this earns marks: It states the governing ethical idea, translates it into public administration, uses a concrete Indian illustration, acknowledges a limit, and ends with a reasoned verdict.

Solved PYQ 3 - 2020 - 20 marks

Question: GS-IV Q10 case study: An honest Municipal Commissioner investigates a fatal mall collapse and finds poor material, unauthorised construction, inspection failures and a prima facie official-builder nexus. Colleagues press for delay, the influential builder offers a bribe, and a threatened POSH complaint is used to demand silence. Discuss the ethical issues, options and selected course of action. (250 words)

Source / ownership: Neutral routing verified against books\more_previous_papers\Gen_St_P4.pdf, pages 8-9. The official multi-paragraph stem and final demand control; this entry condenses the facts for Topic 21's protection, dissent and POSH-process route.

Model solution

The case combines loss of life, corruption, regulatory capture, child labour concerns, friendship conflict, ministerial influence, bribery, pressure from colleagues and weaponisation of a possible POSH complaint. The Commissioner owes duties to victims, lawful construction, fair investigation, colleagues, the complainant if one emerges, and his own procedural protection.

He may slow or suppress the inquiry, recuse entirely, disclose and seek an independent team, or continue with institutional safeguards. Suppression is illegal and betrays victims. Total recusal may protect appearance but can abandon responsibility unless a competent substitute is secured. The best course is to preserve the site, records and electronic trails; provide relief to victims; disclose friendship with the former Commissioner; constitute a multidisciplinary inquiry; record all oral pressure and the bribe approach; and escalate through vigilance and criminal channels.

Any workplace complaint must go independently to a properly constituted Internal Committee. It should neither be dismissed as retaliation without inquiry nor used to halt corruption evidence. Interim reporting lines can avoid contact while both processes continue.

The Commissioner should issue reasoned directions, resist transfer or career threats through written records, and seek protection for witnesses. This preserves accountability for the deaths while demonstrating that honest official protection means due process, not immunity from a separate lawful complaint.

Why this earns marks: It states the governing ethical idea, translates it into public administration, uses a concrete Indian illustration, acknowledges a limit, and ends with a reasoned verdict.

Solved PYQ 4 - 2021 - 20 marks

Question: GS-IV Q7 case study: Sunil, a young civil servant confronting an illegal sand-mining mafia supported by local functionaries and insiders, faces threats to himself and surveillance of his family. Identify his options, critically evaluate them, and select the most appropriate course of action. (250 words)

Source / ownership: Neutral routing verified against

books\more_previous_papers\QP-CSM-21-GENSTUDIESPAPER-IV-110122.pdf, pages 4-5. The official paper supplies the complete case; this routing retains the nexus, threats, family risk and three-part demand.

Model solution

Sunil can withdraw, seek transfer, continue alone, negotiate informally, or build a protected institutional response. Withdrawal rewards coercion and harms communities; transfer may protect family but leaves the network intact. Acting alone shows courage but creates avoidable safety and evidence risks. Informal compromise is unacceptable where organised crime and official collusion are involved.

He should document threats and operational facts, secure evidence outside the compromised office, inform senior police and administrative authorities in writing, request assessed protection for family and witnesses, rotate sensitive personnel, and form a multi-agency team covering mining, transport, revenue, police and financial trails. Insider access should be restricted through need-to-know controls and access logs. Raids must remain lawful, intelligence-led and supervised.

If local channels are captured, Sunil should use higher vigilance or authorised anti-corruption routes and seek judicial protection where necessary. Media disclosure should not be the first step because it may expose sources and operations. A transfer request can be reconsidered after evidence and continuity arrangements are secured, not as immediate surrender.

The course combines courage with prudence. Integrity does not require reckless martyrdom; it requires sustained public action, institutional escalation, personal safety and an auditable trail that makes retaliation visible.

Why this earns marks: It states the governing ethical idea, translates it into public administration, uses a concrete Indian illustration, acknowledges a limit, and ends with a reasoned verdict.

Solved PYQ 5 - 2022 - 10 marks

Question: GS-IV Q6(a): Whistle-blower, who reports corruption and illegal activities, wrongdoing and misconduct to the concerned authorities, runs the risk of being exposed to grave danger, physical harm and victimization by the vested interests, accused persons and his team. What policy measures would you suggest to strengthen protection mechanism to safeguard the whistle-blower? (Answer in 150 words)

Source / ownership: Exact English wording verified against books\more_previous_papers\QP-CSM-22-GENERAL-STUDIES-PAPER IV-190922.pdf, page 4.

Model solution

Protection must cover the full disclosure cycle. First, provide secure authorised channels with identity segregation, encrypted records, acknowledgement and jurisdiction routing. Only designated officers should access identity, and every access should be logged. Second, require prompt threat assessment, police protection where needed, safe transfer on the complainant's request, witness protection and emergency contact arrangements.

Third, create a rebuttable review of adverse transfers, appraisals, suspensions, contracts or harassment occurring after disclosure. Interim relief and restoration should be available without waiting for final prosecution. Fourth, time-bound independent investigation should separate the disclosure's merits from retaliation complaints. Malicious falsehood may receive proportionate action only after intent is proved; mere inability to prove corruption should not attract punishment.

Finally, publish anonymised outcomes, impose personal consequences for identity leakage, train officers, and permit escalation beyond a captured department. The Whistle Blowers Protection Act's non-commencement makes dependable administrative channels especially important, but reform should ultimately provide an operational statutory regime. Confidentiality without safety and remedy is incomplete protection.

Why this earns marks: It states the governing ethical idea, translates it into public administration, uses a concrete Indian illustration, acknowledges a limit, and ends with a reasoned verdict.

Solved PYQ 6 - 2022 - 20 marks

Question: GS-IV Q8 case study: Ramesh, a State Civil Services officer in a border State, submits a confidential report on illegal migrant infiltration and forged documents. A superior orders withdrawal and threatens loss of his capital posting and promotion. Examine his options, preferred course, ethical dilemmas and relevant policy measures. (250 words)

Source / ownership: Neutral routing verified against books\more_previous_papers\QP-CSM-22-GENERAL-STUDIES-PAPER IV-190922.pdf, pages 8-9. The official paper contains the complete factual narrative and five-part demand.

Model solution

Ramesh faces conflict between lawful duty and obedience, national security and humane treatment, family needs and public interest, confidentiality and escalation, and career pressure versus integrity. Withdrawal protects his immediate posting but falsifies the record. Public leakage may trigger action but compromises intelligence, privacy and operations. Silent refusal without escalation may preserve conscience yet leave the threat untreated.

He should ask for the withdrawal direction in writing, preserve the original report and supporting evidence, record a reasoned dissent, and seek review by the competent senior authority through secure channels. The report should distinguish verified infiltration, suspected official complicity and untested inference. A multidisciplinary investigation should protect intelligence sources while testing document and financial trails. If departmental capture persists, he should use authorised vigilance, security or judicial channels rather than partisan or public disclosure.

He should disclose the personal posting and promotion pressure but not allow it to determine substance. Any transfer should be challenged through recorded reasons and applicable review, while continuity of investigation is secured.

Policy measures include secure border systems, document-authentication audits, staff rotation, anti-collusion controls, reasoned transfer policy and protected reporting. His answer should be firm but evidence-based: written dissent protects integrity only when followed by lawful escalation and operational follow-through.

Why this earns marks: It states the governing ethical idea, translates it into public administration, uses a concrete Indian illustration, acknowledges a limit, and ends with a reasoned verdict.

Solved PYQ 7 - 2023 - 20 marks

Question: GS-IV Q10 case study: Vinod, an honest IAS officer and Managing Director of a State Road Transport Corporation after six transfers in three years, receives documents and a video alleging bribery by the politically powerful Chairman. The opposition source offers future career support, while exposure may cause another transfer. Evaluate Vinod's options and the ethical issues arising from politicisation of bureaucracy. (250 words)

Source / ownership: Neutral routing verified against books\more_previous_papers\QP-CSM-23-GENERAL-STUDIES-PAPER-IV-180923.pdf, pages 10-11. The official stem controls; this entry preserves the transfers, evidence, political incentives and two-part demand.

Model solution

Vinod can ignore the material, immediately publicise it, align with the opposition, confront the Chairman alone, or verify and route it institutionally. Ignoring credible evidence breaches fiduciary duty. Public disclosure may taint evidence and convert administration into partisan contest. Accepting promised advancement creates a fresh conflict even if the allegation is true. Solo confrontation risks destruction of records and retaliation.

Vinod should acknowledge the source without accepting political terms, make a conflict record, secure copies and metadata, and order lawful discreet verification by a competent team. Procurement files, payment trails, tender criteria and communications should be preserved. If the threshold is met, he should refer the matter through the CVO or competent anti-corruption channel, recuse from any step creating personal conflict, and maintain confidentiality. He should document threatened transfer and seek review under applicable tenure policy while ensuring an institutional handover if moved.

Politicisation produces transfer markets, partisan loyalty, selective exposure, policy discontinuity and public distrust. Its cure is not bureaucratic unaccountability but published posting criteria, fixed tenure with reasoned exceptions, board-level controls and independent investigation.

Vinod must be non-partisan in method and fearless in substance. Evidence, not the source's electoral interest or the Chairman's proximity to power, should determine action.

Why this earns marks: It states the governing ethical idea, translates it into public administration, uses a concrete Indian illustration, acknowledges a limit, and ends with a reasoned verdict.

Solved PYQ 8 - 2024 - 20 marks

Question: GS-IV Q8 case study: Raman, a newly posted State Director General of Police, confronts online recruitment of unemployed youth by a global terrorist group. State intelligence indicates targeting of a particular community and extremist social-media activity. Examine his options, measures to strengthen the existing setup and an action plan for better intelligence gathering. (250 words)

Source / ownership: Neutral routing verified against books\mains\05 UPSC 2024 Paper-IV_Final 1.pdf, pages 5-6. The official paper provides the complete case. Topic 21 uses it for calibrated screening, investigator accountability and protection against indiscriminate suspicion.

Model solution

Raman must act against a credible security threat without equating unemployment, community identity, dissent or heavy social-media use with terrorism. Options range from mass coercive action to passive monitoring; both extremes fail. Blanket profiling can alienate citizens, generate false positives and obscure actual recruiters, while delay permits mobilisation.

He should establish a legally supervised, intelligence-led task force that verifies source reliability, maps recruiter networks and distinguishes advocacy, radical belief, preparation and criminal action. Targeted digital forensics should follow authorisation, necessity, proportionality, access controls and audit logs. Community leaders, educational bodies, employment agencies and mental-health or counselling services can support prevention and credible counter-messaging. At-risk youth should receive exit pathways rather than automatic criminal branding.

The intelligence system needs trained analysts, multilingual capability, inter-agency fusion, source protection, false-positive review, periodic legal audit and independent complaint handling for abuse. Officers should record reasons for intrusive measures and supervisors should review discriminatory patterns.

The ethics of honest-official protection applies to investigators too: clear rules and recorded approvals protect lawful decisions, while accountability for fabrication, profiling or leakage prevents impunity. Raman's objective is precise prevention that protects both public safety and constitutional trust.

Why this earns marks: It states the governing ethical idea, translates it into public administration, uses a concrete Indian illustration, acknowledges a limit, and ends with a reasoned verdict.

ORIGINAL MAINS PRACTICE WITH MODEL SOLUTIONS

Original Mains Practice 1 - 10 marks

Question: Explain how the bona fides test protects honest administrative risk-taking without creating immunity for negligent or corrupt decisions. Answer in about 150 words.

Model solution

The bona fides test asks whether a person of common prudence, acting within prescribed rules and on the information then available, could have taken the decision in the organisation's genuine interest. It corrects outcome bias: a failed loan, procurement or policy experiment is not automatically misconduct.

Protection depends on process evidence. Contemporaneous reasons, due diligence, expert consultation, disclosed conflicts, equal treatment and absence of personal benefit support good faith. Concealed interests, fabricated records, deliberate rule evasion or reckless disregard defeat it. ARC's warning that every loss need not become a vigilance case preserves managerial initiative.

The test is therefore neither subjective intention nor blanket immunity. Screening should separate error, negligence and corruption; competent investigators should then pursue actual knowledge, benefit and collusion. A reasoned, evidence-based test protects honest risk while keeping culpable conduct accountable.

Why this earns marks: The response defines the issue, develops the relevant mechanism with India-centric evidence, tests a limitation, and gives a mark-scaled conclusion.

Original Mains Practice 2 - 10 marks

Question: Why do specificity screening and secret preliminary verification need both confidentiality and external accountability? Answer in about 150 words.

Model solution

ARC recommends testing allegations for specificity, credibility and verifiability before formal inquiry. This filters revenge complaints from disciplined subordinates or blocked beneficiaries and prevents accusation alone from damaging an honest officer. Secret verification also preserves evidence and reputation: if the claim is false, unnecessary publicity is avoided.

Yet secrecy can conceal institutional inaction. A captured vigilance unit may indefinitely shelve a specific complaint, protect senior officials or deny the complainant any traceable outcome. Confidentiality must therefore be paired with registration, time limits, recorded reasons, supervisory review and anonymised reporting. Identity access should be restricted, while closure remains reviewable by a competent independent authority.

The correct design separates privacy from invisibility. Verification should be discreet enough to protect persons and evidence, but accountable enough to prevent secrecy from becoming impunity.

Why this earns marks: The response defines the issue, develops the relevant mechanism with India-centric evidence, tests a limitation, and gives a mark-scaled conclusion.

Original Mains Practice 3 - 15 marks

Question: Differentiate Section 17A and Section 19 of the Prevention of Corruption Act, and assess the significance of the Supreme Court's split decision of 13 January 2026. Answer in about 200 words.

Model solution

Section 17A addresses an early stage. It requires prior approval before enquiry, inquiry or investigation into an alleged Prevention of Corruption Act offence relating to a recommendation made or decision taken in discharge of official functions, subject to the statutory on-the-spot exception. Its purpose is to protect official decision-making from vexatious investigation. Section 19 operates later: previous sanction is required before a court takes cognizance of specified offences against a covered public servant. Thus investigative approval and prosecution-cognizance sanction must not be conflated.

The former rank-based single directive in Delhi Special Police Establishment Act Section 6A was struck down in 2014 under Article 14. Section 17A is differently framed around conduct rather than rank, but its capacity to block even preliminary police action remains contested.

In *Centre for Public Interest Litigation v. Union of India*, the two judges delivered divergent opinions on 13 January 2026. The official order directed placement before the Chief Justice for an appropriate Bench. It therefore supplies no common final holding on constitutionality.

The ethical verdict remains calibrated: honest decisions need protection, but approval must be prompt, independent, reasoned and reviewable so that procedure does not become a shield for corruption.

Why this earns marks: The response defines the issue, develops the relevant mechanism with India-centric evidence, tests a limitation, and gives a mark-scaled conclusion.

Original Mains Practice 4 - 15 marks

Question: Investigator accountability and protection against arbitrary transfers are complementary requirements of ethical vigilance administration. Discuss. Answer in about 200 words.

Model solution

Vigilance can harass without proving guilt. ARC identified over-suspicion: investigators may treat a wrong outcome as corruption and implicate every person in the decision chain. This lowers precision, demoralises honest officials and can let actual wrongdoers escape. Its proposal for a specialised unit to examine corruption or harassment by investigators recognises that independence cannot mean immunity. Such review should test fabrication, selective targeting, delay and conflict while protecting bona fide investigative judgment.

Transfer is a second, softer instrument. ARC's transfer-industry diagnosis shows how political control of postings can punish dissent without formal proceedings. Published policies, minimum tenure, recorded grounds for premature movement and independent appeal make retaliation visible. The Fifth Pay Commission's three-to-five-year norm, with shorter tenure for especially sensitive posts, supplies a concrete reform anchor.

Both safeguards need qualifications. Investigator review must not permit accused officials to intimidate agencies, and tenure cannot block urgent reassignment where conflict or evidence risk is established. Narrow exceptions, written reasons and external review reconcile operational flexibility with integrity.

Together, accountable investigation and fair postings protect lawful courage while preserving consequences for misconduct.

Why this earns marks: The response defines the issue, develops the relevant mechanism with India-centric evidence, tests a limitation, and gives a mark-scaled conclusion.

Original Mains Practice 5 - 20 marks

Question: A procurement officer is orally directed by a Minister to favour an unqualified bidder and is threatened with transfer. Design the officer's written-dissent and whistleblowing response. Answer in about 250 words.

Model solution

The officer should first prevent an irreversible award without converting disagreement into personal confrontation. She should seek the direction in writing and make a contemporaneous file note recording the tender criteria, bidder's deficiency, public-finance risk and lawful alternatives. If any personal connection exists, it must be disclosed and recusal considered. A committee using pre-published criteria should complete evaluation so that discretion is not concentrated in one person.

If pressure continues, she should record a reasoned dissent, cite the applicable rule and ask the competent superior to review. Relevant bids, communications, access logs and meeting records should be preserved securely. The concern should then move through the authorised vigilance or CVO channel. If that route is captured, escalation may proceed to the competent independent anti-corruption authority. Public disclosure is a last resort for grave residual harm after lawful channels fail; premature leakage can prejudice procurement and expose witnesses.

The transfer threat should also be documented. She may seek review under published tenure policy and request a reasoned order, but must ensure a secure handover if moved. Resignation is not the first response because it abandons the file and citizens unless continued service demands direct illegality.

Safeguards must not become self-exoneration. An independent body should verify the allegation, and the bidder and Minister must receive lawful process. The officer's protection rests on evidence, consistency and good faith, not merely on claiming to be honest. The course combines deontological refusal, consequential protection of funds and virtue-based courage with institutional prudence.

Why this earns marks: The response defines the issue, develops the relevant mechanism with India-centric evidence, tests a limitation, and gives a mark-scaled conclusion.

Original Mains Practice 6 - 20 marks

Question: Design a vigilance system that protects honest officials, fairly handles POSH complaints and prevents procedural safeguards from becoming impunity. Answer in about 250 words.

Model solution

A sound system begins with symmetric risk: malicious allegation and investigative overreach can destroy honest initiative, while captured approvals, secrecy and hierarchy can shield corruption or harassment. Protection must therefore attach to good-faith process, not status.

At entry, every corruption complaint should be registered securely and screened for specificity, credibility and verifiability. Confidential preliminary checking should protect reputation and evidence, but carry deadlines, reasons and supervisory review. Technically competent, impartial teams should examine the decision trail, conflict disclosures, benefit, knowledge and deliberate deviation. Prosecution should focus on strong evidence rather than every file signatory. Section 17A approval and Section 19 sanction must remain stage-distinct, prompt and reviewable. A separate mechanism should examine fabricated cases, selective investigation, identity leakage and retaliatory delay by investigators.

The POSH route must remain independent. The Internal Committee should receive written complaints, protect confidentiality and participants, provide interim safeguards, define allegations, hear the respondent and issue reasoned recommendations. A threatened or actual POSH complaint must neither be dismissed merely because a vigilance case exists nor be used to freeze corruption evidence. Separate teams, restricted information sharing and anti-retaliation monitoring preserve both processes.

Published transfer policy, minimum tenure, reasons for premature movement, protected whistleblowing channels and review of adverse career action address informal retaliation. Aggregate reporting should reveal delays without exposing identities.

The final principle is protection without impunity: honest risk receives fair screening and defence, complainants receive safety and voice, investigators receive operational space, and every actor remains answerable through reasons, evidence and independent review.

Why this earns marks: The response defines the issue, develops the relevant mechanism with India-centric evidence, tests a limitation, and gives a mark-scaled conclusion.